



THE ANCIENTS NEVER RAISED THEIR BUILDINGS SO HIGH

**BRUNELLESCHI DESIGNS THE DOME
OF FLORENCE CATHEDRAL (1420)**

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

The Renaissance

BEFORE

1296 Building work begins on the Santa Maria del Fiore cathedral (Il Duomo), Florence.

1305 Giotto completes his frescoes at the Arena (Scrovegni) Chapel in Padua.

1397 The Medici bank is founded in Florence; becomes the largest bank in Europe.

AFTER

1434 Cosimo de' Medici becomes de facto ruler of Florence and supports the arts.

1447 Francesco Sforza comes to power in Milan. His court becomes a center of culture.

1503 Leonardo da Vinci starts work on the *Mona Lisa*.

1508 Michelangelo begins to paint the Sistine Chapel ceiling in the Vatican.

In 1418, the wealthy Guild of Wool Merchants of Florence launched a competition to find a design for a dome to complete their unfinished cathedral—the Cattedrale di Santa Maria del Fiore, commonly known as Il Duomo. The city

of Florence was one of the richest in Italy, a center of banking and trade and it was on the basis of this wealth that the city could afford to commission a cathedral dome of unprecedented size.

This lavish spending on art and architecture would soon be echoed across Italy, as the region's growing prosperity meant that rulers and rich citizens could spend money to beautify their towns and enhance their prestige. The strong economy and deep civic pride in Italy laid the foundations for one of the most significant intellectual movements in history: the Renaissance.

Il Duomo

At the time of the competition, Florence's cathedral featured a vast octagonal space toward its eastern end, but since work on



Dominating the skyline of Florence, Brunelleschi's groundbreaking dome remains the tallest building in the city, rising majestically from the surrounding red-tiled roofs at 374ft (114m) high.